Paul’s Admiration for the Thessalonians

A faith growing under testing, a love that reaches each one, endurance worth boasting about — and to such a church God gives an undisputed promise and Paul an undefeated prayer.

Where this study fits

2 Thessalonians · seven studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–2
Introduction and Background

02 1:3–12
Paul's Admiration for the Thessalonians

03 2:1–5
Confusion Concerning the Coming

04 2:6–12
The Removal of the Restrainer

05 2:13–17
The Day of the Lord and Believers

06 3:1–12
Serving While Waiting

07 3:13–18
My Brother's Keeper

Grace and peace frame the letter (1:2; 3:16–18): persecution in chapter 1, prophecy in chapter 2, correction in chapter 3.

Praise, promise, prayer

2 Thessalonians 1:3–12 · Outline I–III

I · Undiluted praise · 3–4

- Bound to give thanks
- For growth — faith
- For grace — love
- For glory — boasting

II · Undisputed promise · 5–10

- The proof: judgment of saints and sinners
- The present: rest
- The prospect: revelation, revenge, reward

III · Undefeated prayer · 11–12

- Always, to our God
- Counted worthy of the calling
- His name glorified in you

What is the promise? God is in control. Every situation you find yourself in, God is in control.

Why Paul was bound to give thanks

2 Thessalonians 1:3–4 · I.A–B — A word of undiluted praise

For growth · 3b
ὑπεραυξάνω grows exceedingly

- Tested exceedingly → growing exceedingly
- Like muscles at the gym
- Like the oak in the wind

For grace · 3c
ἕκαστος each one · G1538

- Love “of each one of you all”
- A nickel for each — not for everybody
- Leave no one out

For glory · 4
καυχάομαι boast · G2744

- Paul boasted of them at Corinth
- Their patience and faith in persecution
- Are we spreading the word?

ὀφείλω “we are bound” — a debt Paul owed God every time he thought of this church (again in 2:13)

Entering the kingdom — and ruling in it

2 Thessalonians 1:5–6 · II.A — The proof of the promise

Judgment of saints · v.5

καταξιόω counted worthy · G2661

- Every believer enters the kingdom (John 5:24)
- Faithful sufferers are counted worthy to rule
- At the Judgment Seat of Christ — not for sin
- The believer gets the reward; God the glory

vs

Judgment of sinners · v.6

- God repays with tribulation those who trouble you
- They are amateurs; God is the professional
- Meanwhile, give them the Word
- Saul heard Stephen — and the Lord got him

"If we endure, we shall also reign with Him" (2 Tim 2:12). Entrance is by faith alone; reigning is a reward for faithful endurance.

Rest now — revelation, revenge, reward to come

2 Thessalonians 1:7–10 · II.B–C — The present and the prospect

v.7a	Rest with us — relief: resting in Jesus for the outcome	**ἄνεσις** relaxation, relief
v.7b	Revealed from heaven with His mighty angels — the Second Coming	**ἀποκάλυψις** a public unveiling
v.8	Vengeance on those who don’t know God and don’t obey the gospel	**—** two groups, one outcome
v.9	Everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord	**ὄλεθρος · αἰώνιος** as long as everlasting life
v.10	Glorified in His saints, admired among all who believe	**ἐνδοξάζομαι** in His saints — “in, not by”

Coming for His saints — or with them?

2 Thessalonians 1:7–10 · Study Note — Rapture or Second Coming?

The Rapture

- He comes for His saints
- Meets them in the air (1 Thess 4:16–17)
- No judgment on the world mentioned

vs

The Second Coming · 1:7–10

- He comes with His saints and mighty angels
- To the earth, in flaming fire, in judgment
- At the end of the Tribulation

Believers on the earth will look at the church returning with Him and see Christ in us. We can’t make His name more glorious — but we can make His glory more well known.

A word of undefeated prayer

2 Thessalonians 1:11–12 · III.A–B — When and what Paul prayed

A

Always

To our God — theirs and ours

v.11a

B

Counted worthy

Of the high calling, in the Spirit's power

ἀξιόω · v.11b

C

His name glorified

In you, and you in Him

v.12

D

Stand firm

Don't run from affliction

by grace

"What was true for the church at Thessalonica is certainly the standard for all of us" — a faithful life that honors His name as we look for His coming.

Discuss and apply

2 Thessalonians 1:3–12 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why was the Thessalonians' faith growing "exceedingly," and what illustrations does the teacher use?

2. How does the teacher explain being "counted worthy of the kingdom of God" (1:5)?

Apply

Welcome the Wind
Name one current trial in prayer each day this week and thank God for the faith He is building through it.

Rest — God's Got Your Back
Memorize 2 Thessalonians 1:7a and pray it whenever pressure comes.

In one line: Tested faith grows, love reaches each one, God will set things right — so rest in Him and let His name be glorified in you.